ZikShare

ACADEMIC VAULT

UNIZIK FRESHER EDITION | 2026

Memory and Active Recall: Remember More With Less Rereading

How memory actually works, and how to study in line with it

STUDY SKILLS

Study Skills

General Studies (GST / CED)
GST Directorate | 100L

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

Study smarter. Ask better questions. Pass with understanding.

Independent study support | Not an official UNIZIK publication

START HERE

Why this pack exists

Memory is not a recording device. This pack explains encoding, consolidation and retrieval, then converts that into concrete practice: retrieval questions, spaced schedules, flashcards done correctly and techniques for formulas and vocabulary.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Explain encoding, consolidation and retrieval in simple terms.
- Design retrieval questions instead of highlighting notes.
- Build and use a spaced-repetition schedule for a semester.
- Use mnemonics and elaboration without relying on them alone.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

How memory works

Information must be encoded, consolidated and retrievable. Each stage can fail.

- Encoding depends on attention and meaningful processing.
- Consolidation happens over time, especially with sleep.
- Retrieval strengthens memory more than rereading.
- Cues help retrieval; learning with varied contexts creates more cues.
- Forgetting is normal and can be countered with spaced review.
- Stress and sleep deprivation impair all three stages.

Retrieval in practice

Turn every page of notes into questions.

- Write questions on the left of the page and answers on the right.
- Close the notes and answer from memory before checking.
- Mark each attempt: confident, shaky or failed.
- Review failed items the next day, shaky items in three days.
- Mix old and new questions in one session.
- Use past questions as retrieval practice, not just as prediction.

> **The flashcard rules**
> One fact per card, a question on the front and a short answer on the back. If a card takes more than ten seconds to understand, split it.

Spacing, sleep and mnemonics

Timing matters as much as technique.

- Review after one day, three days, one week, two weeks and one month.
- Short frequent sessions beat one long session.
- Sleep after study supports consolidation; all-nighters trade memory for anxiety.
- Mnemonics help with lists but do not replace understanding.
- Elaboration - asking why and how - creates stronger, more flexible memories.
- Explain a topic aloud; gaps become obvious immediately.

PRACTICE, NOT PREDICTION

Check your understanding

These questions are written for this pack to test the ideas above. They are not past examination questions and do not predict what your lecturer will set. Answer first, then compare.

1. Why is retrieval stronger than rereading?

Answer: Retrieval requires reconstructing information, which strengthens memory traces and reveals gaps; rereading only creates familiarity.

2. Give a workable spaced-review schedule.

Answer: Review one day, three days, one week, two weeks and one month after first learning.

3. What is wrong with a flashcard containing a whole paragraph?

Answer: It is too complex to retrieve quickly; one fact or concept per card works better.

4. How does sleep affect memory?

Answer: Sleep supports consolidation, stabilising and integrating newly learned information.

5. When are mnemonics useful?

Answer: For ordered lists, names or sequences; they aid recall but should be paired with understanding.

Your 7-step action plan

Tick each step only when you have done it. A tick you cannot defend is worse than an empty box.

- [ ] Convert one lecture into ten retrieval questions.
- [ ] Test yourself with notes closed and mark each answer.
- [ ] Build a spaced-review schedule for one week.
- [ ] Create 15 single-fact flashcards.
- [ ] Explain one topic aloud from memory for two minutes.
- [ ] Track sleep for a week and note its effect on recall.
- [ ] Re-test a topic after seven days and compare with day one.

Keep going

One pack will not carry a semester. Pair this with your lecture notes, tutorials, and the past questions your department actually releases. If a topic still feels unclear, take a specific question to your lecturer or course rep - "I do not understand the difference between X and Y" gets a better answer than "I do not understand this course".

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YOUR WORKSPACE

Notes, questions and things to ask

Use this page in class or during revision. Write questions you could not answer instead of copying slides.

Three ideas I can now explain without notes:

A question I still cannot answer:

For my lecturer or course rep:

Next revision action and date:

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